

REAL WORLD

Emoticons

In the digital world, punctuation marks, especially the colon, are used to create informal graphic representations of emotions known as “emoticons.” The most frequently used marks are the colon, semicolon, and parenthesis, but almost any punctuation mark can be used.



Basic smile



Sad face



Winking smile



Smile with open mouth



Embarrassed face



Surprised face

Quotes

A colon is often used to introduce quoted text, especially literary quotations, where the author’s exact words are repeated.

She was quoted in the newspaper: “I love socks!”

Quoted text follows the colon.

Titles

A colon is sometimes found in the titles of works of literature, film, art, and music. If the title is followed by a subtitle, a colon separates the two.

Socks: The Sure-footed Life of a Collector

main title

The subtitle follows the colon.

Bible references

When giving a Bible reference, the chapter and verse are separated by a colon.

1 Corinthians 13:12

book of the Bible

A colon separates the chapter and verse.

chapter

verse



- A colon never follows a **verb**.
- A **dash** can be used instead of a colon, but a **colon creates a greater pause** and a sense of anticipation for what follows it. Use a dash for emphasis and drama.
- A colon should be followed by **one space**.
- The **first word** following a colon should be **lowercase**, unless it begins a main clause.